

Top performers



Most runs

Brian Bennett (right)

Runs: 180; SR: 124.13; Avg: 180.00

Tadiwanashe Marumani

Runs: 104; SR: 157.57; Avg: 26.00

Sikandar Raza

Runs: 102; SR: 167.21; Avg: 51.00

Most wickets

Blessing Muzarabani (below)

Wickets: 11; Avg: 10.27; Eco: 7.06

Brad Evans

Wickets: 9; Avg: 13.56; Eco: 8.51

Richard Ngarava

Wickets: 5; Avg: 12.80; Eco: 8.00

(Stats updated after the first Super Eight match against WI)

— inspiration, motivation, passion. But what he does consistently is lead through his actions. He is vocal in the dressing room, yet people follow him because of the brilliance he produces. He is meticulous about constantly trying to improve, and I think that's what keeps him going," Ebrahim says.

Another big factor in plugging the gap with the best teams has been franchise cricket. Raza is a franchise-cricket globetrotter, having played in every major league from the Indian Premier League to the SA20. Ryan Burl, Muzarabani and Ngarava have also enjoyed stints overseas.

Explaining the significance of franchise cricket, Raza says: "Myself and all the other cricketers who have gone overseas for franchise cricket have always come back and spoken to the boys — about what happens there, what works on those wickets, what works in certain situations. If the boys haven't got the experience, the least we can do is share the knowledge."

Hence, it was not surprising that Zimbabwe felt it had a shot. It is no stranger to wins at global showpiece events. It had defeated Australia in the group stage of the 2007 T20 World Cup as well. The need to banish the demons of previous

misses added extra motivation.

"One of the goals we set was to bring more recognition and respect to our country. Whatever happened in the past has happened, but this group has been together for a long time and has gone about its business with utmost honesty and integrity. To now see everybody taking notice of Zimbabwe and viewing it in a respectable manner is certainly very humbling and pleasing," Raza says.

The pre-seeded Super Eight groups were an underwhelming confrontation for Zimbabwe eventually. It received no incentive for finishing first in Group B and was pitted against title contenders India and South Africa, as well as West Indies.

But even if its fortunes turn for the worse in this World Cup, Zimbabwe has turned heads and earned itself a launchpad. The Super Eight qualification guarantees the team a place in the next World Cup, bringing with it freedom from the Regional Qualifiers.

The momentum could not only thrust Zimbabwe further in T20 cricket but also revive its ODI fortunes, where it has not qualified for a World Cup since 2015. It now has the talent — and the belief — to emulate this year's feat in the longer white-ball format.



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